

PTO and Leave Policy

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1. Purpose and Scope

This policy covers paid time off (PTO), sick leave, parental leave, bereavement leave, jury duty, and unpaid leave of absence for regular Solarium employees. Part-time employees accrue benefits on a pro-rated basis according to scheduled hours. Interns and fixed-term employees under 90 days follow the accrual rules in Section 9. Where local law provides a more generous benefit than described here, local law governs, per SOL-GOV-000.

2. Paid Time Off (PTO) — Accrual

Solarium uses an accrual-based PTO system rather than an unlimited or "flexible" PTO model, because our internal research and employee feedback consistently showed accrual-based systems result in employees actually taking more time off, not less.

Years of Service	Annual PTO Accrual	Accrual Rate
0–2 years	15 days/year	1.25 days/month
3–5 years	20 days/year	1.67 days/month
6+ years	25 days/year	2.08 days/month

- PTO begins accruing from your first full month of employment; your hire-month accrual is pro-rated based on start date.
- PTO accrues monthly and is available to use as it accrues — you do not need to wait until year-end.
- Part-time employees accrue the same rate multiplied by their scheduled FTE percentage (e.g., a 0.5 FTE employee at 0–2 years accrues 7.5 days/year).

3. Requesting and Approving PTO

- 1 Submit your request through the PTO system as far in advance as practical — at least 2 weeks for anything longer than 3 consecutive days, and at least 5 business days for shorter requests, though we recognize life doesn't always cooperate with advance notice.
- 2 Your manager approves or discusses conflicts within 3 business days. Approval is not typically withheld except for genuine team coverage conflicts (e.g., two people on the same critical project requesting the same week) — if that happens, your manager should work with you to find an alternative date rather than a flat denial.
- 3 PTO is tracked in half-day increments at minimum; some teams support hourly tracking for partial-day needs — check with your manager.
- 4 There is no company-wide blackout period, though individual teams may set brief blackout windows around major, pre-announced launches, communicated at least 4 weeks in advance.

4. PTO Carryover and Payout

- Up to **5 days** of unused PTO may be carried over into the next calendar year. Any balance above 5 days as of December 31 is forfeited, except where state or local law requires otherwise (several U.S. states, for example, prohibit "use-it-or-lose-it" PTO policies entirely — in those states, all accrued and unused PTO carries over, per the applicable state addendum).
- Upon voluntary or involuntary termination, unused accrued PTO is paid out in your final paycheck **where required by state or local law**. In states without such a requirement, Solarium's default practice is to pay out unused accrued PTO up to a maximum of 10 days as a matter of company policy, not legal obligation — check the state addendum for your location for the exact treatment.
- PTO does not earn interest and cannot be borrowed against future accrual beyond 5 days negative balance, which requires manager approval.

5. Sick Leave

Sick leave is tracked separately from PTO so that being unwell never competes with your vacation time.

- **Accrual:** 1 hour of sick leave per 30 hours worked, up to a maximum accrual of 72 hours (9 days) per year, consistent with or exceeding applicable state sick leave laws.
- **Use:** Sick leave may be used for your own illness or injury, medical appointments, mental health days, or to care for an immediate family member who is ill. No doctor's note is required for absences of 3 consecutive days or fewer; for absences longer than 3 consecutive days, a note from a healthcare provider may be requested by People Operations (not your manager directly) to support continued leave and coordinate with short-term disability if applicable.
- **Carryover:** Unused sick leave carries over up to the annual cap (72 hours); it is not paid out upon termination unless required by local law.
- Using sick leave in good faith is never grounds for discipline. If you notice a pattern where sick leave use seems to reflect a bigger issue (chronic illness, burnout, caregiving strain), talk to People Operations about accommodation options — that conversation is confidential from your manager unless you choose to involve them.

6. Parental Leave

- All parents (birth, adoptive, and foster), regardless of gender, are eligible for **12 weeks of paid parental leave** at 100% of base pay, usable within 12 months of the birth, adoption, or foster placement.
- Birth parents recovering from childbirth are additionally eligible for medical leave for the recovery period (typically 6–8 weeks, as certified by a healthcare provider), which runs concurrently with, not in addition to, the 12 weeks where medically appropriate, but never reduces the 12-week parental leave benefit below its full value.
- Parental leave can be taken continuously or split into at least two blocks within the 12-month window (e.g., 8 weeks at birth, 4 weeks later) with 2 weeks' notice for the second block where practical.
- Parental leave runs concurrently with FMLA or equivalent state/local job-protected leave where applicable, so that you get the greater of the two, not a sum.

- Eligibility begins on your first day of employment — there is no waiting period, unlike some companies' 90-day or 1-year tenure requirements.

7. Bereavement Leave

- **5 paid days** for the death of an immediate family member (spouse/partner, child, parent, sibling, grandparent, grandchild, or an equivalent close relationship).
- **2 paid days** for the death of an extended family member or close friend, at manager discretion for anyone not covered by the "immediate family" definition above.
- Bereavement leave can be taken non-consecutively within 60 days of the death to accommodate travel, services held later, or the wave of logistics that often follows a loss.
- Additional unpaid bereavement leave or use of PTO/floating holidays is available on request — you will never be pushed back to work before you're ready within a reasonable window, and your manager should default to flexibility here.

8. Jury Duty and Civic Leave

- Solarium provides paid leave for jury duty and legally required court appearances (e.g., subpoenaed as a witness) for the full duration, with no cap on days, since this is a civic obligation outside your control.
- Provide your manager and People Operations with the jury summons as soon as you receive it.
- If jury service is only partial-day, you're expected to work the remainder of the day if reasonably possible.
- Voting leave: Solarium provides up to 2 paid hours for voting in any public election if your work schedule doesn't otherwise allow enough time to vote, consistent with (and meeting or exceeding) state voting leave laws.

9. Pro-Ration for Part-Time, Fixed-Term, and Intern Employees

- Part-time employees accrue PTO and sick leave at their FTE percentage as described in Sections 2 and 5.
- Fixed-term employees on contracts of 90 days or longer accrue PTO and sick leave on the same basis as regular employees for the duration of their contract.
- Interns and fixed-term employees under 90 days accrue sick leave only, per state law minimums, and do not accrue PTO; floating holidays are pro-rated per SOL-HR-102.

10. Unpaid Leave of Absence

For circumstances not covered by paid leave categories above (e.g., extended personal leave, leave beyond parental leave's 12 weeks), employees may request an unpaid leave of absence:

- 1 Submit a request to your manager and People Operations at least 30 days in advance where the need is foreseeable, or as soon as possible if it is not.
- 2 People Operations will confirm whether the leave qualifies for job protection under FMLA or an equivalent state law, and will explain how benefits continue (or don't) during unpaid leave.

- 3 Health insurance coverage can generally continue during an approved unpaid leave of up to 12 weeks if you continue paying your normal employee contribution; beyond 12 weeks, COBRA or equivalent continuation coverage applies — People Operations will walk you through the specifics before your leave begins, not after.
- 4 A company holiday falling within unpaid leave is not paid, since there is no active pay status to apply the holiday to.

11. Returning from Leave

Employees returning from an approved, job-protected leave return to the same or a substantially equivalent role, consistent with applicable law. Reach out to your manager and People Operations at least 2 weeks before your planned return date to coordinate re-onboarding, especially if you've been out for an extended period — this is standard practice, not a sign anything is wrong.

Frequently Referenced Numbers

- PTO accrual: 15 / 20 / 25 days per year based on tenure (0–2 / 3–5 / 6+ years)
- PTO carryover cap: 5 days
- Sick leave accrual: 1 hour per 30 hours worked, capped at 72 hours/year
- Parental leave: 12 weeks at 100% pay, no waiting period
- Bereavement: 5 days (immediate family) / 2 days (extended family or close friend)
- Jury duty: fully paid, no cap
- Voting leave: up to 2 paid hours

Related documents: SOL-HR-102 (Holiday Calendar), SOL-HR-103 (Benefits Guide), SOL-GOV-000 (Handbook Overview).